

How to Nurse a LOONSHOT in 20m a Day

Big Ideas, AI, & Limited Time



The Moment Demands High Ambition

The cost of failure is trending towards zero

- High upside of ambitious experiments:
accelerating learning, time to value, augmenting our toolset...
- Lean into the mindset of reaching for the (yet) impossible
- The most impactful advances recently have come from reaching for big changes, trying wild ideas

Loonshots:

Wild, seemingly crazy ideas that have the potential for massive breakthroughs

...also acceptable: **ordinary**
ideas about hard things
that you otherwise don't have
time to pursue

With AI tools across every discipline, **the bottleneck now is sustained cognitive attention.**

Great ideas die more often from neglect than technical impossibility.

We must feed them if they are to grow.



As a team, we have to make
this shift – All it takes is one hit
to lift all of us...



...but I have to ship software!

I have a “squad” to take care of...

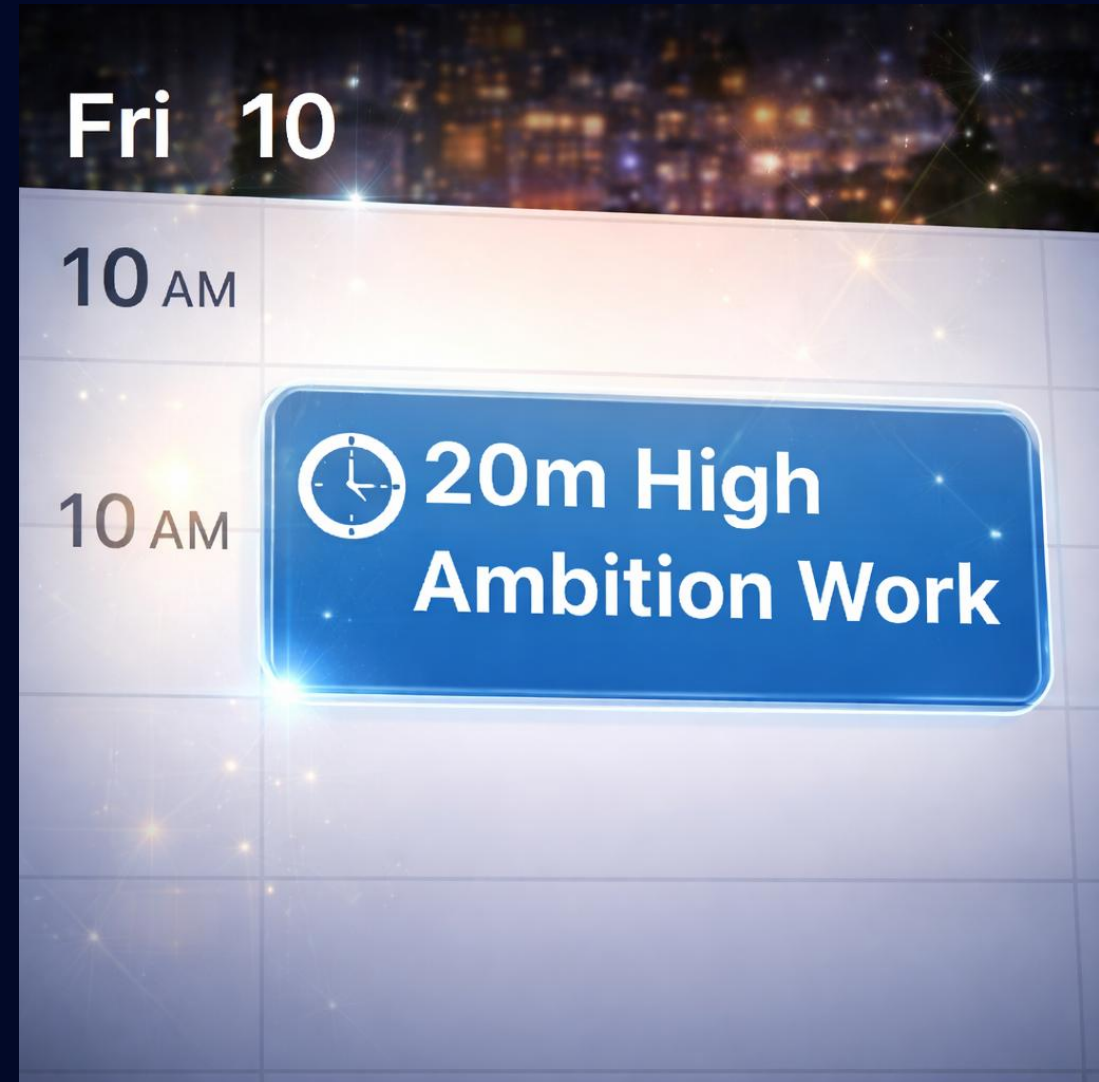


Commit to 20 minutes a day

The AI tools can page context in and out for you, and they can work while you are away.

Example 20 Minute Framework

- Friday – Generate 10 Impossible Ideas
- Monday – Narrow to One
- Tuesday – Identify the Barriers
- Wednesday – Decompose, Identify Metrics
- Thursday – Build Agents to Help You!
- Friday – Distribute, Eval, and Explore
- Week 2 – Iteration, Reflection



Tip: build your framework and write it down and then paste it into the AI chat as context...

“here’s how we are going to work through this exploration...”

Friday – Ten Ideas

Write down ten ideas that feel out of reach.

Quantity over quality – push to ten

This is like a gym exercise: Stretching beyond your first 2–3 ideas builds cognitive range and creative stamina.

Paste the list into an AI assistant and ask for help narrowing.





Ten ideas
won't cost you that much!
You can do it!

Monday – Narrow to One

Write down a few sentences that capture:

- **Who is the user?**
- **What are you building?**
- **What outcome do they want?**
- **Why does it matter?**

While you are gone: Ask the AI to gather related research, OSS projects, industry/competitor analysis etc.

Your filtering criteria reveal your motivations and constraints.

Tip: each day – when you wrap up – ask the AI to summarize your progress and next steps

Tuesday – Identify Barriers

What makes this impossible today?

- Scale? Money? Unknown tech? Coordination?
- For each barrier: What if it were removed?

While you are gone: ask the AI to explore how others have approached these specific constraints.

Many impossibilities are poorly defined constraints.

Wednesday – Decompose, Identify Metrics

- Break Barriers into grist for parallel explorations
- Ask AI to propose multiple investigation strategies
- How will you measure progress?
- How can you state the objective as a measurable goal?
- *While you are gone: have the AI work on strategies for evaluating the measurement.*

Ambition becomes more tractable when decomposed

Thursday – Build Agents to Help You



- Use AI Coding tools to design one or more agents to pursue the goal.
- Ensure that it can iterate, modify its approach, and compare results via eval
- *While you are gone: have the agent build any tools it needs along the way*

Delegating goal pursuit changes how you think about solving the problem

Friday – Distribute, Eval, and Explore

- Have the agents generate a distribution of possible approaches
- Run parallel experiments
- Compare results and update strategy
- *While you are gone: have an agent review the week and suggest experiments to run next week*

Progress can emerge from variation and selection

Week 2 Iteration Structures

You can give a variety of structures to follow-up – employ patterns from the first week:

- Have the AI keep context for you about the status and next steps.
- Keep looking for the long running tasks you will delegate.
- Plan the week ahead and then break the plan into smaller steps.
- Use the end of one day to tee up the next.



Knowing When to Quit

Consider stopping when:

- Marginal progress flatlines across multiple branches.
- Core assumptions are invalidated.
- The opportunity cost exceeds potential upside.
- A better loonshot emerges.

Reframe quitting as reallocating ambition.

Learning from Failure

- Capture failed hypotheses.
- Extract reusable tools or insights.
- Identify new constraints discovered.
- Feed learnings into next Friday's idea generation.

Tip: keep a journal (or running chat with AI) capturing notes, things you've learned, etc. across all of your experiments or ambitious explorations.

What to Do When You Break Through

- Pause and validate.
Expand measurement rigor.
- Shift from exploration to scaling.
- Socialize internally.
- **Ask the Agents to help you teach the breakthrough.**
- Decide whether this graduates from loonshot to roadmap.